MAIR Thesis Supervision Guidelines 2025

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Process of supervisor assignment

In the second block of their first semester, students submit a literature review on the basis of which students are assigned to supervisors by their MAIR specialization—i.e., Culture and Politics, European Union Studies, Global Conflict in the Modern Era, Global Order in Historical Perspective, and Global Political Economy. Students are allowed to indicate a preference for supervisors whose research interests match their own.

We try to match student projects to supervisor interest and specialization as well as we can based on available supervisors and student projects. This is a complex puzzle and we cannot guarantee a perfect fit. Note that we generally do not facilitate a change of supervisors except in extraordinary circumstances that render the original supervisor unavailable. A change of topic is generally not sufficient cause for a change of supervisor.

Allocation of second readers

Second readers are also assigned by MAIR specialization. We do not expect second readers to have substantive expertise on the topic of the thesis. To ensure a fair distribution of the workload, and accounting for the level of involvement within the program, staff are expected to act as second reader on a number of theses no greater than the number of theses they are expected to supervise.

General guidelines

MAIR supervision is expected to start upon assignment and supervisors are encouraged to meet students shortly after assignment. These meetings should help students set goals for the upcoming winter or summer break during which supervisors are generally not expected to be available for supervision. Supervisors should note that MAIR thesis submission is limited to two deadlines per academic year and that the deadline comes early in the semester and that students are expected to make significant progress over the break—see deadlines below.

For the *Onderwijs- en Examenregeling* regarding MA theses at the Faculty of Humanities of Leiden University (on which these guidelines are based) see:

http://hum2.leidenuniv.nl/pdf/oer/Regulations-concerning-the-MA-thesis-13-14.pdf

Thesis supervision model

While supervision is a highly individual undertaking, in an effort to ensure fair supervision of all students, we suggest the procedure below. Supervisors are free to supervise more intensively, but at a minimum, it is expected that supervisors should meet with students at least four times. The length of these meetings will vary (the first meeting will most likely be longer than the last) but they should not take up more than an hour each. The following meeting structure is suggested:

Meeting 1: An introductory discussion concerning the choice and scope of the thesis topic, the research question, the literature, the source materials, the general approach, consultation with appropriate experts, etc. The timetable for submissions should also be agreed during this meeting.

Meeting 2: A discussion following the submission of the introduction/literature review/research design;

Meeting 3: A discussion following the submission of an empirical chapter during the intermediate stage of the thesis process.

Meeting 4: A discussion of the final evaluation.

Some supervisors are opting to supervise in thesis research groups. How they manage this is up to them, but the idea is generally that they combine group and individual supervision. For example, instead of four individual meetings, you might only have two, plus two or three longer joint meetings where you discuss common issues, or peer review other students'. This works particularly well if students are working on a specific project with the supervisor or if students' research topics are similar.

With regard to the extent to which supervisors provide written or oral feedback on submitted chapters, the following guidelines are recommended: It is advised that supervisors will provide oral or written feedback on the introduction/literature review/research design and at least one subsequent chapter during the period of supervision. Supervisors are allowed but not required to read and provide feedback on an entire draft of the thesis. Supervisors will communicate their supervision style to students during the first meeting.

Supervisors cannot be expected to edit poor language. If students are struggling with writing in English, please have them contact the faculty's Writing Centre:

http://www.hum.leiden.edu/students/expertise-centre-academic-skills/writing-center/writing-centre.html.

Research ethics

Supervisor and student should discuss any potential ethical implications of the research during their initial meeting or when they first arise. Ethical implications should always be considered

when the research involves human participants or the use of individually identifiable data. Particular care should be taken with vulnerable groups, such as asylum seekers or citizens of authoritarian regimes. The program will not allow any thesis research that has the potential to endanger the researcher or participants.

When conducting interviews, the student should acquire informed, voluntary consent to participate in the research from all participants (for example interviewees). This involves providing participants with an information sheet that explains the nature, aims and implications of the research project, the nature of participation and any other considerations that might reasonably be expected to influence their willingness to participate.

The privacy and confidentiality interests of participants must be protected throughout the research process. Information that may identify individual persons should not be used in research findings unless the person has expressly agreed to its release, having had the opportunity to consider the implications of such release. This can be done by asking interviewees to sign a consent form, which includes an acknowledgement that they have read and understood the information sheet, and details whether they consent to being identified in the thesis or whether they prefer to remain anonymous. Researchers should respect the right of individuals to refuse to participate or, having agreed to participate, to withdraw their consent at any stage without prejudice.

For sample consent forms, see:

- https://www.eui.eu/Documents/ServicesAdmin/DeanOfStudies/ResearchEthics/sampleInformedconsentform.pdf
- https://www.ed.ac.uk/files/imports/fileManager/Interview_Consent_Form.pdf
- http://www.ncl.ac.uk/res/research/ethics_governance/ethics/toolkit/consent/consent_form_example.doc

For additional information, also see the attached *Code of Ethics*.

Thesis assessment

Both the first and second readers will assess the thesis based on the criteria set out by the Exam Committee (see Appendix A) and in the MA thesis assessment form (see Appendix C). Please note that the MA thesis assessment form must be filled out correctly — i.e. the examiner's 'motivation' for each of the criteria must be specified in full in the correct box

Please note that the research *process* is a necessary component for the evaluation of a thesis. The process allows the supervisor to both evaluate the knowledge that the student gained from the program and ensure the integrity of the examinations. While the thesis is an independent project, the student cannot submit a thesis for evaluation that has not been overseen by a supervisor. The student should therefore actively consult their supervisor during the research process.

Note: because there is no supervision during the winter and summer breaks, this requirement of supervising the process implies that theses cannot be written in their entirety over the summer or winter break.

In line with faculty regulations, examiners are asked to submit their grades within *four* weeks of receiving the thesis; students should be aware that grading can take longer during the summer. Theses can receive a grade between 0-10 (see the grade descriptors in Appendix B), with the exception of grades *between* 5.0 and 6.0— e.g., a grade of 5 or 6 is permitted, while a grade of 5.1, 5.5, or 5.9 is not.

Because students come from different disciplinary backgrounds and write their theses under supervisors who work in different traditions, we do not have uniform expectations for the final product. It should, however, conform to the basic requirements of a thesis at the MA level. *Please refer to grading guidelines under Appendix A below.*

Fit with specialization. The thesis should fit the specialization. In reality there will always be some overlap in the subject choice of students from different specializations, not least because many of our own interests stretch beyond singular disciplinary and subject-related confines. Nevertheless, the thesis is envisaged as the culmination of studying a particular set of core courses and electives over several months. Students should thus be expected to write a thesis that builds upon, and makes use of, the knowledge, topics, methods and/or skills gained from following a specific specialization.

The responsibility of fit lies first with the student, but the supervisor should see to it that the thesis fits the specialization. In rare cases when the student doesn't heed the advice of the supervisor, the supervisor can evaluate fit as part of the learning skills (process) section of the evaluation. The second reader comes in too late to evaluate the fit of the thesis. We suggest that the second reader does not make fit part of their evaluation, but that they flag poorly fitting theses to the thesis coordinator, so we can adapt our policies.

In rare cases, students do a double specialization. Note that double theses have an explicit requirement of substantive content addressing the core themes of both specializations. The supervisor and second reader evaluate whether the thesis adheres to this substantive requirement. We refer to our dual specialization policy for additional details.

Plagiarism

The unacknowledged reproduction of the work, words, or ideas of another person constitutes plagiarism (for faculty regulations, please see the *onderwijs en examenregelingen*). Students therefore should cite their sources and paraphrase—never just 'copy' or moderately edit original text. Any work found to be plagiarised or to contain plagiarism will receive, at the very least, a mark of zero. The maximum penalty for plagiarism is expulsion from the programme. Please take this matter seriously; there are cases of this kind every year.

The supervisor will check the thesis for plagiarism through the system before a thesis can be approved for correction. Report any suspicion of (self-)plagiarism to the Exam Committee (examencomIR@hum.leidenuniv.nl).

If there is a suspicion of plagiarism, please explain it. Sometimes the source of suspicion is obvious but sometimes it is not. Please attach the original document and the Turnitin/SafeAssign report to your e-mail. Please also indicate at least three passages that you find suspicious of plagiarism, including the original source from which the student is supposed to have plagiarised. Please also inform the student that you have reported the suspicion to the Exam Committee. Note that any allegation of plagiarism will be sent to the student who has the right to respond.

Thesis deadlines and submission

Students must submit their thesis as a by email to their supervisor with CC to the second reader. Students should ask for confirmation that their thesis is received and submitted. If you do not receive confirmation, please ask again after one week.

We encourage students to complete their thesis in the second semester of their studies, but we have no required completion time for the thesis or supervision. Students are allowed to delay their thesis for whatever reason. However, we only have a single deadline to submit the thesis each semester. If this deadline is not met, the next opportunity for submitting the thesis in the following semester. The deadlines are: Friday 6 December, 2024; Friday 6 June, 2025; and Friday 5 December 5, 2025.

Students are allowed a single retake for the thesis if it fails, which can submitted at any time. Students who fail their thesis and resubmit their revised thesis by the last workday of January (for the December deadline) or August (for the June deadline) can still graduate within the same month. Note that theses cannot be written in their entirety over summer or winter break—see above.

Students who want to extend the semester deadline should consult their supervisor and second reader, who both need to approve the extension. If they approve the extension, the student does not have to submit a request with the Board of Examiners. Please consider that extension requests have to be discussed with the supervisor and second reader well before the deadline, and can result in a later graduation date as the student will likely not have sufficient time to submit a retake by January or August. It may also mean the student cannot participate in the graduation ceremony. If the request for an extension is not approved, please contact stucomair@hum.leidenuniv.nl. In that case the student is advised to contact the Board of Examiners, who base their decision on a hindrance statement from the student counsellors. The supervisor and second reader will be informed of the outcome.

Style and formatting

- Theses have a **maximum** word count of 15.000 words, which includes all elements (e.g., notes, bibliography and appendices). This is a hard maximum and does not allow for a 10% margin.[1]
- It is important that one reference style be used consistently.
- The thesis should
  - be written in English;
  - be written in Word;
  - use 1,5 line spacing, standard margins and a standard size 12 font;
  - include the student's name, email, and student number as well as the word count (including all elements) on the title page;
  - include the student's student number on all subsequent pages;
  - have been proofread for spelling and language errors.

[1] See appendix A, Faculty regulation master's thesis FGW, art. 2.

APPENDIX A—thesis grading guidelines

I. Quality criteria

• The thesis should include a clearly formulated research question.
• The thesis should include a critical and analytical report on existing academic debates based on secondary literature.
• The thesis should include an original contribution to academic debates. In principle, the thesis should be of sufficient quality (possibly following some modifications) to be published in an academic journal in the relevant field.
• The thesis should be based on primary sources, if applicable and appropriate for this particular research project.
• The thesis should display the application of concepts and research methods.
• The thesis should display a clear and sufficient degree of structure and proper use of language.
• **Fraud and plagiarism are 'knockout criteria'**, and suspicions thereof have to be reported to the Exam Committee (see Chapter 2: Guidelines on suspicions of plagiarism).

II. Standards for awarding a particular grade

The exact grade to be awarded depends on the extent to which the above-mentioned quality criteria are fulfilled, such as:
• The originality of the research question and the manner in which it has been out into practice.
• The clarity of the structure.
• The student's display of knowledge and insight.
• The quality of the critical analysis of secondary literature.
• The quality of the use of theory.
• The quality of use of an appropriate method.
• The quality of the critical analysis of primary sources.
• Logical and consistent reasoning.
• The quality of the analysis of the material presented in the thesis.
• The quality of the conclusion of the work.
• The quality of language, structure and style.
• The degree and measure of independence displayed during the research and supervision process, the learning curve and ability to deal with feedback and comments.

Further references:

• OER, Appendix A Regulations concerning the procedure surrounding the master's thesis
• Examples for feedback are provided in the online assessment forms for BA, MA and research MA theses (http://www.hum.leidenuniv.nl/osz/formulieren/beoordelingsformulieren-ba-eindwerkstukken-en-research-ma-scripties.html)
• MAIS and EUS thesis supervision guidelines

APPENDIX B

MA International Studies, Leiden University

GRADE DESCRIPTORS FOR ESSAYS AND OTHER ASSESSED COURSEWORK

9-10 *A+ – distinction*	An outstanding answer showing an excellent understanding of the issues and methodologies; original, independent thinking informs an answer based upon rigorous argument accurately supported by evidence derived from a wide range of source material; at the top end of the scale, the work could not be expected to be bettered at the MA level in the time available.
8-8.9 *A – merit*	An answer demonstrating an excellent level of understanding of the issues and methodologies; the answer displays independent thought, and strong and well organised argument, using a wide range of sources.
7-7.9 *B – merit*	A good to very good answer showing most but not necessarily all of the above.
6-6.9 *C – pass*	An answer demonstrating satisfactory understanding of the issues, with a reasonable and reasonably well organised argument supported by a standard range of sources. The answer may display some shortcomings, but no fundamental errors.
5.1-5.9	**The faculty does not issue grades in this area**
3-5.0 *F – fail*	An answer which shows inadequate understanding of the issues raised by the question, with substantial omissions or irrelevant material. Poorly conceived and poorly directed to the question.
2-2.9 *F – fail*	An attempt to answer the questions, but without any significant grasp of material or appropriate skills.
0-1.9 *U – ungradable*	No answer offered; or an answer which is totally irrelevant, fundamentally wrong, or plagiarised.

APPENDIX C—Assessment form Master's thesis Leiden University – Faculty of Humanities

Programme		Specialisation	
Date		EC	
Name student		Student number	
Title thesis			
First evaluator		Second evaluator	

1. Is the thesis in your judgment free of plagiarism?

○ Yes ○ No

2. The standard procedure is that Master's theses in the repository are public, unless the student or lecturer has good reasons to keep the thesis confidential, or temporarily confidential. Please indicate this below.

- **This thesis may not be made public through the repository.**
- **This thesis can be made public through the repository no earlier than __-__-20__ .**

Criteria (see the back of this form for the subcriteria)	**Assessment**
Knowledge and insight (contents, relation to the field)	**Optional: weighting: … %**
Comments:	○ excellent ○ good ○ acceptable ○ insufficient
Application knowledge and insight (methodology)	**Optional: weighting: … %**
Comments:	○ excellent ○ good ○ acceptable ○ insufficient
Reaching conclusions (interpretation, argumentation, conclusion)	**Optional: weighting: … %**
Comments:	○ excellent ○ good ○ acceptable ○ insufficient
Communication (writing skills, structure)	**Optional: weighting: … %**
Comments:	○ excellent ○ good ○ acceptable ○ insufficient
Learning skills (process)	**Optional: weighting: … %**
Comments:	○ excellent ○ good ○ acceptable ○ insufficient
Formal requirements	
Comments:	

Summary assessment/ comments

Signature first evaluator	**Signature second evaluator**	**Final assessment[2]**

[2] (*scale of 1 to 10, not necessarily the average of the sub-assessments above*)

Subcriteria assessment **Master's thesis** (to be supplemented with programme-specific requirements related to programme-specific objectives)

Knowledge and insight (contents, relation to the field) Dublin descriptor: Has demonstrable knowledge and insight, based on the knowledge and insight at the Bachelor level and surpassing and/or expanding this, as well as offering a basis or an opportunity to make an original contribution to the development and/ or application of ideas, often in the context of research.
E.g. • *the research question is based on a problem that reflects insight into the key discussions and methods of the field;* • *clarity, relevance, and definition of the problem;* • *embedding in the existing literature;* • *originality.*
Application knowledge and insight (methodology) Dublin descriptor: Is capable of applying knowledge and insight and problem-solving abilities in new or unfamiliar circumstances within a broader (or multidisciplinary) context which is related to the specialisation; is capable of integrating knowledge and to handle complex matters.
E.g. • *critical analysis of primary material/ primary sources (quality of the analysis);* • *putting into practice and usage of complex concepts;* • *usage complex and effective research methods;* • *usage secondary sources which are meant for an advanced academic audience;* • *description and justification of the adopted method;* • *application of knowledge and insight into (unfamiliar) circumstances within a broader (or multidisciplinary) context.*
Reaching conclusions (interpretation, argumentation, conclusion) Dublin descriptor: Is capable of reaching conclusions based on incomplete or limited data and with that taking into consideration social and ethical responsibilities which are connected to the application of the own knowledge and opinions.
E.g. • *logical and consistent reasoning; conclusions are well-founded and follow logically from the presented material;* • *degree to which the thesis question is actually answered;* • *degree to which results are connected to other and future research;* • *social and ethical aspects taken into consideration in reaching a conclusion;* • *critical reflection on own role as researcher (social and ethical responsibilities).*
Communication (writing skills, structure) Dublin descriptor: Is capable of clearly and unambiguously conveying conclusions, as well as the knowledge, grounds and considerations that form the basis of these conclusions, to an audience consisting of specialists or non-specialists.
E.g. • *language use (language of instruction and/ or target language of the programme: degree of linguistic competence, readability, style, spelling, grammar, use and explanation correct terminology);* • *structure and layout of the thesis (division into chapters and sections,table of contents, used illustrations);* • *apparatus including annotations (correct use of reference guidelines, completeness of references, bibliography, etc.).*
Learning skills (process) Dublin descriptor: Possesses the learning skills necessary to proceed in studies which require a high degree of autonomy or self-regulation.
E.g. • *degree of independence;* • *planning and time management;* • *handling feedback supervisors;* • *If applicable: participation in thesis group.*
Formal requirements
E.g. Number of words